couple of decades later by post-liberal, post-modern and certainly post-Christian society. True, in this new society, Eastern Europe had hardly taken any part in its creation. It could only attempt to copy it.

Moreover, with the approaching centenary of World War II and the last Holocaust survivors and Allied soldiers laid to rest, there have also been increasingly fewer references to the lessons of World War II. The war is now a distant memory.

But the legacy of the victory over Communism has been evaporating at an even faster pace and has now for some time been seen as something deserving no more than a passing acknowledgement. In any event, it has been increasingly seen as their (Eastern Europeans') victory.

As a result, the contribution of Eastern Europe to the formation of European identity has been minimised in many quarters, worthy of little more than polite acknowledgement. At worst, references to its historical contribution to Europe are taken as a historic curiosity and another confirmation of the region's social conservatism. At best, Eastern Europe's tragic experience of Communism and courageous victory over it are still honoured in speeches at solemn occasions, but with little real importance given to them. As the generation that brought about these changes is dying out, so is the memory of it – and the attachment of real significance to it. What is more, the Communist issue now seems to be used, at least in some places, as an excuse by the power-hungry populists of Eastern Europe trying to justify their capture of the state and attacks on liberal democracy. Communism also became a taboo, very much like fascism.[94]

But has the Communist legacy indeed disappeared? Or is it still lurking in the very fabric of the post-Communist societies? Is it in any way still of relevance? Are its consequences still with us or are the conservative Eastern Europeans kicking a dead body?

The most serious blow that Communism delivered to Eastern Europe was not to the economy; it was to people's self-confidence.[95] Western European society is built on the premise of trust between people, on the assumption that people are, in principle, honest and trustworthy. Not so in Eastern Europe, where (at least in the past) an individual was treated with suspicion in most social situations. He or she could not be trusted as a matter of principle; their trustworthiness needed to be proved in advance. For all its talk about Humanism, Communism saw the diversity of individuals as the